Centre offers Rs 10,000 crore," Stalin declared at a public event.

Beyond the language controversy, Stalin and his party strongly oppose several structural changes proposed in the NEP. Among them is the introduction of common entrance exams for undergraduate admissions, which the Tamil Nadu government believes will disproportionately disadvantage students from underprivileged backgrounds who do not have access to expensive coaching institutes. The Tamil Nadu government maintains that its existing education model, which has produced high literacy rates and successful professionals across various industries, does not require a structural overhaul dictated by the Centre.

Pradhan emphasises that the NEP is not a rigid mandate but a flexible framework that states can adapt to their regional needs. He points out that several non-BJP states have implemented it despite political differences, arguing that Tamil Nadu's opposition is political rather than based on educational justification. He adds that the policy aims to provide students with a well-rounded education that balances core knowledge with practical skills, aligning with global standards.

However, the real issue lies in execution and political trust. Tamil Nadu fears that once the NEP is adopted, the Centre will dictate its implementation in a way that erodes state autonomy. The BJP, on the other hand, sees the resistance as politically motivated, aimed at keeping the DMK's anti-Hindi, pro-state autonomy narrative alive. With neither side willing to back down, the impasse seems likely to continue. The standoff has larger implications for federal relations in India, with states like Kerala and West Bengal also resisting aspects of the NEP. The deadlock highlights the importance of dialogue and cooperation between the Union and states beyond political motives.■

BSP

IT'S ALL ABOUT MAYA

By Avaneesh Mishra

Behenji may be down, but not out. That is what the leaders and cadres of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) have been telling themselves for the 13 years since Mayawati was last chief minister of Uttar Pradesh. But a series of unpredictable actions—and none more bizarre than divesting nephew Akash Anand of all party responsibilities—has left them unsure. The action against Akash follows his father-in-law Ashok Siddharth's expulsion last week. If Akash was widely seen as Mayawati's chosen heir, Siddharth was her closest aide. A former Rajya Sabha MP, he played a significant role in ticket distribution and alliance negotiations and handled key responsibilities in the southern states. "She had even married off her nephew to his daughter," says a BSP functionary.

If Siddharth was removed ostensibly for encouraging groupism and anti-party activities, Akash's dethronement was on account of Siddharth's alleged undue influence on him via his daughter. "For this, not the party but his father-in-law Ashok Siddharth is completely responsible," Mayawati declared in a post on social media platform X. To fill the vacuum, the BSP supremo named her younger brother Anand Kumar, who is the party's national vice-president, as its national coordinator too. But with Kumar opting to retain only one post, party leader Randhir Beniwal was entrusted with the latter responsibility.

More importantly, in a series of

PTI



HEIR NO MORE? Mayawati with nephew Akash Anand